

Collected Works

From cardboard coins to stamps, polythene bags to pre-paid cellphone cards, stationery to autographs, every member of this family has a collection going

Rajasthan
Gwalior
Uttar Pradesh
MADHYA PRADESH

Maharashtra

RAVI UPADHYAYA



THE FAMILY WITH ITS ASSORTMENTS

| By Ambreesh Mishra |

All kinds of people collect odd things and their family members think of them as the odd one out. But here is a family where everyone collects. The lead is taken by H.B. Maheshwari, 62, who has won international awards for his rare collections of stamps and coins. He has cardboard coins issued by the state of Jaisalmer during the metal shortage of World War II and also interchangeable postal and revenue stamps from the Gwalior state and the Raj. The state coins from Gwalior are minted in copper, silver and gold. His collection includes the entire official stationery of the two princely states. His wife Kiran Bala, 58, too is a collector, and a pioneer after she successfully convinced the INPEX philately exhibition organisers in 1980 to allow the display of fiscal stamps. Her fiscal stamps from the Datia state were used for postal purposes as well.

Son Neelkamal is into philology—taking autographs of celebrities on their photographs. It's a painstaking effort as many object to the use of printed photos or those downloaded from the Internet on grounds of copyright. Now, he shoots photos himself and gets them auto-

graphed. "Rajanikanth doesn't sign autographs so I had to make numerous visits and calls," says the 30-year old. His collection includes the two Bills—former US President Bill Clinton and Microsoft Chairman Bill Gates—apart from signed autobiographies of Jawaharlal Nehru, the Dalai Lama, M.F. Husain and Dev Anand. He proudly shows off a khadi sheet with a certain 'M.K. Gandhi' scrawled on it. Neelkamal's wife Hema, 26, too has collected nearly 7,000 pre-paid phone cards from 35 countries.

Maheshwari's daughter, Kamakshi, 23, collects plastic carrybags from people and gives them jute ones in exchange. "My collection of about 3,500 polybags from different countries, ranging from three cm to six feet, will remind people about our green-averse ways," she says. But among all these, the prized collection undoubtedly remains that of the family patriarch, who has refused an offer of over Rs 1 crore. "It would be like selling the family silver," Maheshwari says. On the rather unusual hobby that runs in the family, he says crisply: "The family that collects together stays together." ■